

Build Muscle, Burn Fat, and GET RICH EP 336

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Executive Summary

Brandon Carter (Big Brandon Carter) breaks down micro cutting and micro bulking — his 30-year method for staying ripped year-round while building muscle — plus covers keto bulking foods, full-body workout math, bench press strength, and online fitness business niching strategy.

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Intro, Housekeeping & Sponsor Overview 1:01

- Episode 336 of Victory Talk podcast; co-host Movia manages the live chat
- Super chats answered throughout the episode for fitness and money questions
- **Sponsors mentioned:**
 - **Go High Level** — CRM Brandon has used for 8 years to run all his online businesses
 - Used previously: Aweber → Active Campaign → Klaviyo (for Shopify)
 - Builds all websites, landing pages, email/SMS automations through it
 - Schedules short-form content to all three platforms in one upload
 - Free 30-day trial via his link; includes all his templates (landing pages, automations) at no cost
 - **Brandon's Live AI Training** — free live training that Sunday at 7 PM EST
 - Topic: growing an online fitness business using AI

- Promise: framework to make an extra \$300–\$500/day
- Testimonials highlighted:
 - Corey Armstrong: went from 2,000 to ~400,000 Instagram followers, ~400,000 YouTube followers; last month finished at \$40K; record year at \$470,000
 - Leonardo (Mexico): had a full-time job, went part-time first; new monthly record of \$39K
- Will give free AI tools for video editing, client acquisition, lead generation, and training clients
- Brandon edits all long-form YouTube videos with Claude or ChatGPT
- **Thought Repellent** — satirical/joke sponsor; "easy to apply spray to keep the hoes away"; crowdfunded via super chats
- Brief political tangent: Trump's Truth Social post calling AI "super intelligence" — Brandon refuses to adopt the term; 100% of poll respondents said "AI"; Sam Altman confirmed OpenAI has no plans to rename

Super Chat: How to Increase Bench Press Strength 19:05

- Sent by Dream Hopper
- **Key principle: progressive overload** — consistently add load over time
- **Caloric surplus matters:** powerlifters are fat for a reason — a caloric surplus is one of the most anabolic things you can do naturally; getting fatter correlates with getting stronger (especially one-rep max)
- **Rep ranges for max strength:** focus on singles, doubles, and triples (never go above 5 reps if pure 1RM is the goal)
 - Low rep ranges produce less lactic acid, so you can train more frequently — every other day is feasible
 - Going above 3 reps may require more rest days between sessions
- **Micro plates:** instead of adding 5 lbs per side, use 1–2.5 lb micro plates to enable smaller progressive overload jumps
- **Brandon's personal take:** he hasn't maxed out in 15+ years; hit 315+ when young and considered it sufficient
 - Unless competing in powerlifting or a strength-dependent sport, he questions the utility of chasing a 1RM
 - Compares it to playing guitar — a hobby that's fun but not economically necessary

Super Chat: Bulking on Keto — Best Meals & Strategy 22:48

- Sent by Mighty Big Cat
- **Core strategy:** choose high-fat, calorie-dense keto foods
- **Recommended foods:**
 - Avocado — very high in calories
 - Nuts (especially macadamia nuts) — extremely calorie-dense
 - Bacon and fatty cuts of meat
 - Pork in general (naturally fatty)
 - Sardines in oil

- Olive oil — add to any food
- Cheeses
- Keto bars (e.g., Perfect Keto bars: ~250 calories, 10g protein in a small bar vs. a David bar at 150 cal / 20g+ protein)
- Keto muffins/cookies — often surprisingly high in calories
- **Key insight on keto bulking:** you need to eat more calories than you'd expect
 - Hypothesis: without carbohydrates, glucose stays low (below 110), so the pancreas secretes little to no insulin
 - Insulin is an anabolic hormone; in its absence, muscle gain requires a higher caloric load
 - Brandon wore a continuous glucose monitor for a month on keto — the connected app thought he was fasting every day because his glucose was so low and stable
- **Keto science sidebar:**
 - The ketogenic diet was invented by doctors in **1920** to treat childhood epilepsy — pharmaceuticals were too harsh for children's bodies; putting kids on keto stopped seizures
 - In ketosis, the body converts fat into ketones as its primary fuel source in the absence of glucose/glycogen
- **Fat gain risk:** Brandon gained fat on keto at bodyweight × 25 calories (4,000–5,000 cal/day at ~200 lbs), but believes he would have gotten fatter faster on carbs because insulin is "indiscriminately anabolic" — it grows both muscle tissue and fat cells

The Core Method: Micro Cuts & Micro Bulks 29:07

- **The holy grail:** building muscle and burning fat simultaneously is widely considered impossible, especially naturally — but Brandon argues there is a way
- **Two approaches exist:**
 - **Body recomposition (recomp):** small deficit while lifting; Brandon has only seen this reliably work in someone's first year of serious training; depends almost entirely on training history and starting point
 - **Micro cuts + micro bulks:** not technically simultaneous, but produces the same net result — fat lost AND muscle gained within the same overall time window
- **Why traditional bulking/cutting fails for naturals:**
 - Pro bodybuilders bulk for ~12 weeks (getting fat), then do 12-week aggressive pre-contest cuts — they look bad for half the year just to look good on competition day
 - Pro bodybuilders are on growth hormone, high-dose testosterone, and other PEDs — they build more muscle on the bulk AND retain more muscle on the cut than natural lifters can
 - Taking a protocol designed for steroid users, doing less volume, and skipping the drugs = results won't follow
 - Brandon notes many pro bodybuilders die before his current age (45) from PED-related causes
- **The micro cut/bulk concept:**
 - Alternating phases of fat loss focus and muscle gain focus

- Results judged over the combined weeks/months — you end up in the same place as a traditional bulk/cut but never look fat
- Originated from an article by **Bill Phillips** (editor-in-chief of Muscle Media magazine, founder of EAS Sports Nutrition — the first company to bring creatine to market)
 - Bill's protocol used strict 2-week alternating phases; Brandon found this too rigid
 - Brandon's version: take each phase as long as needed, not a fixed time
- **Body fat thresholds (the visual framework):**
 - **~10% body fat** = ripped (Brandon's target lower bound)
 - **~15% body fat** = hormonal danger zone begins
 - **~20% body fat** = "gross" / too fat (Brandon's upper hard limit)
- **The cycle:**
 - Start with an initial cut down to desired leanness (10% or below)
 - Bulk until abs start losing definition / approaching 15–20% — then cut again
 - Repeat indefinitely; Brandon ran this cycle for 30+ years straight
 - 2026 was the first year he stopped doing it (now eating at maintenance)
- **Why cut first (especially if skinny-fat):**
 - Above 15% body fat, you become less insulin sensitive → body uses nutrients less effectively → bulking when fat = more fat gain, less muscle gain
 - Fat cells cause aromatization → free testosterone declines above 15% body fat
 - After a cut, insulin sensitivity spikes → muscles "suck up" nutrients during the subsequent bulk
 - Bodybuilders/physique competitors universally report their best gains come right after a competition (peak leanness = peak insulin sensitivity)

The key insight: Micro cuts and micro bulks mean you're never fat, always building, and the cumulative result is the same as a traditional bulk/cut — but you look good the entire time.

The Micro Cut — Exact Protocol [44:28](#)

- **Calorie target:** bodyweight in pounds × 10 = daily calories
 - Example: 200 lbs → 2,000 calories/day
- **Why this aggressive deficit is necessary (not a 500-calorie deficit):**
 - FDA allows food labels to be inaccurate by **20%** legally — a food labeled 500 calories could be 400 or 600
 - Condiments/sauces add up fast (e.g., 50g of Ray's Sugar-Free Honey Mustard = 200+ calories)
 - A 500-calorie deficit is easily wiped out by label errors plus untracked condiments
 - "Fat loss should not be sustainable" — a caloric deficit is mild starvation by definition; the goal is to get lean fast, then sustain the lean body weight, not sustain the deficit

- **Protein target:** 1 gram per pound of bodyweight, minimum
 - Example: 200 lbs → minimum 200g protein/day (Brandon personally gets 250–300g/day at ~195 lbs)
 - Reasons to keep protein high and not worry about "too much":
 - No proven negative consequences of excess protein
 - Label inaccuracy (20% rule) means you should overshoot to ensure adequacy
 - **Thermogenic effect of food (TEF):**

Macronutrient	Calories burned in digestion
Fat	0–3% of calories consumed
Carbohydrates	10–15% of calories consumed
Protein	20–30% of calories consumed

- Protein functions like a "cashback card" — you absorb less net calories from it than from any other macro
 - Protein is also the primary lever for retaining muscle in a deficit
- **Tracking:**
 - Log everything — food, portions, sauces, condiments
 - Drink nothing with calories
 - Eating the same foods daily makes hitting targets much easier
 - Weigh yourself daily; take the weekly average; if not losing weight, either tracking is wrong or calories need to drop
 - Brandon used MyFitnessPal for 15 years; now uses Claude AI to estimate meals
 - When a food scale isn't available (e.g., courtside at Kaseya Center), he photographs the food and asks Claude to estimate — not as accurate as a scale but far better than nothing
 - Free calorie-tracking prompts available via link in description
- **Lifting during the micro cut:**
 - Keep lifting heavy — do NOT turn weight training into cardio circuits
 - Brandon actually lifts heaviest when cutting
 - Goal: signal to the body that muscle is still required despite the deficit
 - Rep range during cut: **6–8 reps** with heavier weight
- **Full body workouts vs. bro splits (Brandon's strong preference):**
 - Protein synthesis lasts ~48 hours after resistance training — bro splits leave 5 days of potential muscle growth untapped per body part
 - **Volume math comparison (chest example):**

Training Style	Sets/Session	Sessions/Week	Sets/Week	Sets/Year
Bro split (chest day)	12 (4 exercises × 3 sets)	1	12	624
Full body (Brandon's method)	8 (2 exercises × 4 sets)	4	32	1,664

- Brandon gets nearly **3× more annual sets** per muscle group
 - Additionally, bro splits mix compound and isolation exercises; Brandon uses almost exclusively compound (multi-joint) movements → each set is more hypertrophy-effective
 - Splits (push/pull/legs, upper/lower) are acceptable alternatives; full body is Brandon's preference
 - Pre-steroid era: every bodybuilder did full body workouts; bro splits arose because steroids extend protein synthesis, making crushing one muscle group per session viable
- **Brandon's full body workout structure:**
 - 1–2 exercises per body part
 - 2–3 sets each
 - Supersets of opposing muscle groups (e.g., bench press → bent-over rows; incline bench → chin-ups; bicep curls → tricep extensions)
 - Rest: 60–90 seconds between supersets (usually 60); timed with Apple Watch
 - Isolation exercises only for extremities (biceps, triceps) where compound movements are limited
 - Total workout time: 60 minutes max
- **Split workout tip (from Wall Street friends):**
 - Two 30-minute sessions per day (morning before work + evening before home) instead of one 60-minute session
 - Intensity drops as duration increases — splitting creates "two first halves," both at peak intensity
 - Brandon applied this commuting from Queens to a 34th Street Crunch gym in NYC
 - Now with home gym, he breaks workouts into three 20-minute sessions



The Micro Bulk — Exact Protocol [1:26:32](#)

- **Calorie target:** bodyweight in pounds × 20 = daily calories (minimum)
 - Example: 200 lbs → 4,000 calories/day minimum; more is fine
- **Protein target:** same as the cut — 1 gram per pound of bodyweight, always
 - Protein stays constant through both phases
- **When to end the bulk:** when abs start losing definition / you're no longer happy taking your shirt off → switch back to micro cut
 - Brandon doesn't formally measure body fat; uses ab visibility as his gauge
 - Typical micro bulk duration: 2–4 weeks (rarely needs more than 2 weeks for himself)
- **Typical micro cut duration:** 2–4 weeks (initial cut may be longer if starting very fat)
- **Running the cycle indefinitely:** Brandon did this for 30+ years continuously
 - Stopped in 2026; now eats at ~maintenance (~3,000 cal/day max, protein 250–300g)
- **Putting on some fat during a bulk is normal** — the goal is to minimize it and never let it reach the 15–20% threshold

TRT, Peptides & Disclosure 34:21

- Brandon has been on **doctor-prescribed testosterone replacement therapy (TRT)** for a few years, starting just before age 40
 - His testosterone was at the low end of the normal range in his late 30s (not critically low)
 - Current target: ~900 ng/dL (high-normal range); blood work every few months
 - At his natural peak in his 20s: ~1,200–1,400 ng/dL naturally — his TRT level is actually lower than his youthful natural level
 - Message to young men: if you're considering TRT, you either misunderstand it or you want steroids and are using TRT as a label
- All coaching results and methods shared are based on **thousands of natural clients over 30 years** — not personal drug use
- **Peptide stack (personal use, not a recommendation — consult a doctor):**
 - Tirzepatide
 - Tesofensine (Tesomorelin referenced)
 - BPC-157 (intermittently)
 - MOD-GRF / Mod Safe for energy
 - Result: best conditioning of his life eating at maintenance, without extreme dieting effort; abs becoming "too veiny"

Super Chat: Online Fitness Business Niching Strategy 1:32:31

- Sent by M4M-S1X (22 years old, 169 lbs, 8.7% body fat, first year, considering coaching)
- **The competitive landscape:** ~3 million online trainers exist
 - Compare: Chicago has 2 million people; Miami has 400,000 people
 - You cannot compete as a generic trainer — you will fail
- **The framework: Who, What, and How**
 - **Who** = target market (niche down to a specific type of person)
 - **What** = the specific problem you help them solve / your specialty
 - **How** = your mechanism (the specific method or system you use)
- **Brandon's own example when he started:**
 - Who: men aged 25–35
 - What: getting ripped (muscular with low body fat) — rejected all other goals
 - How: intermittent fasting + HIIT cardio
 - The "why" behind the target market: men 25–35 want to get ripped almost exclusively because of women → marketing reflected this (workout videos with women, etc.)
 - 15 years later, you still can't name 10 trainers doing exactly this combination
- **The specialist vs. generalist principle:**

- Specialists always make more money than generalists
- Analogy: would you want a general practitioner doing your laser eye surgery, or a specialist with years of exclusively doing that procedure and countless testimonials?
- All your testimonials become people with the same problem → prospect can't price-shop because almost nobody else does exactly what you do
- **Shifting the "why" by demographic:**
 - Men 25–35: motivation = women/attraction
 - Men 35–45: motivation = health, being present for family, energy to play with kids, being there for daughter's wedding
 - Same marketing wouldn't work across both groups
- **Case study — Jen Caesar (High Ticket Trainer community member):**
 - Was a full-time nurse with two young kids and limited time
 - Husband Allan encouraged her to join the program
 - Niche: "I help busy moms lose fat and get tone" (used the word "tone" intentionally because that's what her target market says)
 - Mechanism: workouts at home (speaks directly to a busy mom's time constraints)
 - Content featured her kids → embodied the target market's values and "why" (being a better mother/wife)
 - Results: January revenue \$39,500; April revenue **\$49,927** (one day short of \$50K); already \$12,577 into May
 - Key insight: "Nobody buys diet and exercise — they buy being a better father, a better mother, a longer life."
- **Age of target market is less important than the type of person and their core problem** — don't put age in your bio; describe the person (e.g., "busy moms")

Super Chat: Specialist Marketing for a Gym Wear Brand 1:58:04

- Sent by Free Bird — personal brand, men's gymwear, daily content question
- **The same Who/What/How framework applies to any product or business**
- **The problem with being a generic gym brand:** you compete directly with Gym Shark, Young LA, Buff Bunny, Alpha Elite, etc.
- **Brandon's off-the-top hypothetical differentiation idea:**
 - Who: male office workers
 - What: clothes you can wear straight from the office to the gym (no change needed)
 - How: proprietary tech + design — possibly athletic breathable slacks, collared shirts that work in both settings
 - Closest existing competitor: Lululemon has some office-to-gym crossover, but doesn't specialize in it — it's a side product, not their identity
 - There are suits you can work out in, but no one wants to go to the gym in a suit → split the difference
 - By specializing exclusively in this, you become the default brand for that use case

- **Brand dilution warning:**
 - Nike could probably make a great suit — but "Nike suit" sounds wrong
 - Brooks Brothers could probably make good athletic gear — but nobody wants it
 - Specialization protects brand identity; adding unrelated products dilutes it
- **Second hypothetical example:** gymwear for pregnant women — "clothes you can work out in or deliver a baby" — likely zero competitors in that exact space
- **Core takeaway:** carve your own lane; who + what + how is the formula for standing out in any saturated market

Super Chat: Should a 31-Year-Old Hop on Test or Peptides? [1:52:24](#)

- Sent by Mighty Big Cat
- **On testosterone:** Brandon does not recommend just "hopping on test" — that's steroids, not real TRT
 - Real TRT = doctor-prescribed, blood work every few months, levels monitored to stay within normal range
 - Brandon's TRT keeps him at ~900 ng/dL — below his natural level in his 20s
- **On peptides:** strongly positive personal experience, but requires doctor consultation before doing anything
 - "Don't tie your shoes without talking to your doctor"
 - His current stack: Tirzepatide, Tesofensine/Tesomorelin, BPC-157 (intermittently), MOD-GRF for energy
 - Currently in some of the best shape of his life eating at maintenance

Super Chat: 17.5% Body Fat — Cut or Bulk? [1:55:23](#)

- Sent by Riley, 41-year-old male, 17.5% body fat, 3 months into a cut
- **Answer: keep cutting — do not bulk above 15% body fat**
 - Above 15%: less insulin sensitive → body uses nutrients less effectively → bulking = more fat gain, less muscle gain
 - Above 15%: fat cells aromatize free testosterone → natural testosterone declines
 - At 17.5% after 3 months of cutting, Riley is close — estimated 1–2 more months of cutting depending on aggression level
 - Then he can bulk as much as he wants

Super Chat: Walking Between Sets [2:05:09](#)

- Brandon does walk between sets personally
- Caveat: he may be more conditioned than the average person
- No strong prescription either way — depends on conditioning level
- Closing reminder: free live training on Sunday (link in description) covering how to grow an online fitness business with AI